their efforts at striking a conversation, dashed into the kitchen to return with a plate heaped hurriedly with juicy fruit slices and some nuts.

Bored eyes brightened momentarily as Zigzag picked up a walnut. But refusing to speak, he dropped one wrinkled eyelid in a solemn wink and flew clumsily to deposit the nut on the enormous chandelier hanging from the ceiling. Bit by bit, and in total silence, all the fruit on the plate was transferred to the chandelier and on to the blades of the ceiling fan (now switched off).

Then perching comfortably on a curtain rod, Zigzag dropped one wizened eyelid in another solemn wink as he sank his beak into a plump guava.

'Don't worry, children,' Visu comforted as he left, noticing how disappointed they looked when Zig zag stubbornly refused to say a single word to them even though they tried speaking to him in English, Hindi, Tamil and French. 'Just wait till Zigzag settles down in this new home, they you can have a great time listening to him.'

As it happened, the children didn't have to wait more than ten minutes to have a great time listening to Zigzag. For as soon as Visu left, Zigzag, still perched on the curtain rod, went off to sleep. And the moment he fell asleep, he began to SNORE!

And what a snore it was Kngrrwheeze!!! It began as a soft grumbly sort of rumble, much like that which the stomach of a mildly hungry dinosaur might have made. Then it grew louder, and louder, and LOUDER until it sounded as if a herd of elephants with cold was trumpeting angrily in the room. KNGRRDRRWHEEZE!!!

Zigzag's snore pounded their eardrums till their heads ached.

In vain did they try to wake the snoring bird. 'Twenty-one languages, he's supposed to know!' snorted Mrs.Krishnan. 'Yet this bird chooses to communicate only in snorish, snorese, snorian, snorihili, snoralu…'

'I thought it was scientific fact that birds couldn't snore,' said Maya, trying to squirt water from a small water pistol at Zigzag to wake him and wetting most of the curtains, the walls and a sofa instead.

'African witch doctor's birds don't obey scientific rules.' Arvind was annoyed that his best imitations of a raging lion, a hungry hyena and a ferocious dog had failed to draw Zigzag out of his deep slumber. Now he tried his loudest, most frightening coyote call.

But Zigzag slept on undisturbed. And snored on.

In total despair at their failure to wake Zigzag, or at least stop him snoring, they shut themselves in the bedroom that was furthest away from Mrs.Krishnan's studio where Zigzag was creating the terrible din. Mrs.Krishnan was just unraveling a roll of cotton wool to stuff in her ears, when they heard their maid,

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